

What Is Veterans Day in the US?

World War I officially ended with the signing of the Treaty of Versailles in France on June 28, 1919.

However, fighting had stopped seven months earlier with an armistice, or an agreement to stop fighting, between the Allied nations and Germany on the eleventh hour of the eleventh day of the eleventh month.

The date, November 11, is now remembered as Veterans Day, a holiday to thank and honor all who served in the United States military.

The celebration first started on November 11, 1919, as Armistice Day. At the time, U.S. President Woodrow Wilson said the day “will be filled with solemn pride in the heroism of those who died in the country’s service and with gratitude for the victory...” The U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs says there were plans to observe the day with parades, public meetings, and a brief suspension of business beginning at 11:00 a.m.

In 1926, the U.S. Congress officially recognized November 11, 1918, as the end of World War I. And in 1938, the body passed legislation to make the 11th of November in each year a legal holiday. Known as “Armistice Day,” it was a day set aside to honor veterans of World War I.

After American involvement in World War II and the Korean War, at the urging of veterans’ organizations, Congress changed the law in 1954 to call it Veterans Day to honor American veterans of all wars.

The date for Veterans Day was changed in 1968 with the signing of the Uniform Holiday Act. With the law, Congress intended to create a three-day weekend for Americans by moving the holiday to a Monday in November. Many states and veterans’ organizations did not agree with this decision. They continued to celebrate the holiday on November 11, leading to confusion. So, Congress returned the holiday to its original date.

Many Americans are confused about Veterans Day and Memorial Day, the other holiday honoring military service, which is observed on the last Monday in May.

The U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs says that both holidays “were established to recognize and honor the men and women who have worn the uniform of the United States Armed Forces.”

Memorial Day is set aside as a day for remembering and honoring those who died in the service of their country. For most Americans, it also marks the unofficial start of summer and a popular weekend for vacationing.

Veterans Day is largely intended to thank and honor all those who served honorably in the military, living or dead, and in wartime or peace.

To ensure that people remember Veterans Day, the U.S. Congress passed, and President Barack Obama signed the Veterans Day Moment of Silence Act in 2016. The law called on the people of the United States to observe a two-minute national moment of silence on Veterans Day at 2:11 p.m. Eastern Standard Time across all states and territories of the United States.

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Vocabulary

solemn - adj. อย่างเคร่งขรึมและเคารพ

gratitude - n. ความรู้สึกขอบคุณ

original - adj. ดั้งเดิม, แรกเริ่ม

intend - v. ตั้งใจ, มีเจตนา

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. When did World War I officially conclude with the signing of the Treaty of Versailles?

June 28, 1918

June 28, 1919

November 11, 1918

November 11, 1919

2. What event, occurring seven months prior to the official end of World War I, marked the cessation of fighting?

The declaration of peace by President Wilson.

An armistice between the Allied nations and Germany.

The surrender of German forces.

The establishment of Veterans Day.

3. What is November 11 now commemorated as in the United States?

Armistice Day

Memorial Day

Veterans Day

Victory Day

4. What was the initial name of the celebration on November 11, 1919?

- Veterans Day
- Memorial Day
- Armistice Day
- President Wilson's Day

5. According to U.S. President Woodrow Wilson, what feelings should accompany the observance of Armistice Day?

- Sadness and remorse
- Solemn pride in heroism and gratitude for victory
- Joy and relief
- Confusion and debate

6. In what year did the U.S. Congress officially recognize November 11, 1918, as the end of World War I?

- 1919
- 1926
- 1938
- 1954

7. When Armistice Day became a legal holiday in 1938, which group of veterans was it primarily intended to honor?

- All American veterans from all wars.
- Those who died in service.
- Veterans of World War I.
- Veterans of World War II and the Korean War.

8. What was the reason behind Congress changing the holiday's name to Veterans Day in 1954?

- To consolidate all federal holidays.
- To honor only living veterans.
- At the urging of veterans' organizations after World War II and the Korean War.
- To simplify the holiday calendar.

9. What was Congress's original intention when signing the Uniform Holiday Act in 1968?

- To return Veterans Day to its original date.
- To create a three-day weekend for Americans.

To combine Veterans Day with Memorial Day.

To limit the number of federal holidays.

10. How did many states and veterans' organizations react to the 1968 change in Veterans Day's date?

They widely accepted the change.

They celebrated it on the new Monday date.

They continued to celebrate on November 11, leading to confusion.

They lobbied for the holiday to be abolished.

11. What is a common source of confusion for many Americans regarding military service holidays?

The specific dates of all federal holidays.

The purpose of the Uniform Holiday Act.

The distinction between Veterans Day and Memorial Day.

The branches of military service being honored.

12. According to the U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs, what is the shared purpose of both Veterans Day and Memorial Day?

To mark the beginning of summer.

To solely honor those who died in service.

To recognize and honor men and women who have worn the U.S. Armed Forces uniform.

To create long weekends for Americans.

13. What additional significance does Memorial Day hold for most Americans, besides honoring the deceased?

It marks the official end of the school year.

It is a day for national civic service.

It marks the unofficial start of summer.

It is a day dedicated to military parades.

14. What is the primary intention of Veterans Day?

To remember and honor only those who died in battle.

To thank and honor all those who served honorably, living or dead, in wartime or peace.

To celebrate military victories and achievements.

To clarify the differences between all military holidays.

15. What legislative action was taken in 2016 to help people remember Veterans Day?

The date of the holiday was changed back to a Monday.

A law was passed requiring a two-minute national moment of silence.

New parades and public meetings were mandated.

The holiday was merged with another national observance.